The Lighthouse Keeper's Daughter

Ada Morrow

Chapter One

Mara learned to read by the light of the lamp her father tended, and so for the rest of her life she associated words with the smell of paraffin and the slow turning of a great glass eye above her head. She read whatever the supply boat brought: almanacs, seed catalogues, a water-stained atlas with half of Africa missing.

Her father did not read. He listened, though, every evening after the lamp was lit, while she read aloud from whatever she had, and he would nod at the hard words as if greeting old acquaintances on the quay.

When she was twelve, a letter came for him. It was the first letter either of them could remember, and he held it for a long time before giving it to her to open.

> Dear Mr Morrow, we regret to inform you that the light on the north rock is to be automated before the end of the year.
> Your service has been exemplary. A cottage on the mainland will be made available to you and your daughter.
> Yours faithfully, the Commissioners.

Her father folded the letter into four and put it in his breast pocket, where it stayed for the rest of the winter, a small square bulge over his heart.

Chapter Two

Leaving took longer than either of them expected. There were the logbooks to copy, the brass to polish one last time, and the long argument with the gulls, who had come to regard the gallery as their own and did not intend to give it up without a fight.

Mara made a list on the back of the last page of the atlas. She called it the list of things that could not be packed:

1. The sound of the foghorn at four in the morning, which she had hated for years and now could not imagine sleeping without.
2. The view from the gallery at dusk, when the mainland looked like a rumour.
3. Her father as he was here, certain of every step on the spiral stair.

She did not show him the list. She suspected he had one of his own, unwritten, and longer.

Chapter Three

The cottage on the mainland had electric light and a kitchen tap and neighbours who waved. Her father kept the lamp oil in the shed anyway, a dozen tins of it, and on clear nights he walked down to the harbour wall and stood watching the north rock, where the new light turned without anyone at all.

Mara went to school, where she discovered that other children had read the other half of Africa. She was not impressed. She had read the sea.